Combat rule – Critical hits · SRD 5.2.1

A **natural 20** on an attack roll always hits and becomes a **critical hit**. Roll the **damage dice twice**, then add **modifiers once**.

It applies to weapon attacks, **spells with an attack roll** and extra dice such as **Sneak Attack**.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. **Natural 20** = hit + critical.
2. Damage dice **doubled**, modifiers **once**.
3. Sneak Attack and spell dice: **doubled too**.
4. Unconscious or paralyzed target within 5 ft: automatic **critical**.

⚠ Change from 2014

SRD 2024 clarifies that extra dice (Sneak Attack, smites) are doubled with the rest.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The SRD doesn't say what a "natural 1" does. Fix: it's just a miss, with no fumble table.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe a crit as a perfect strike: a breach, a weak point, an explosion.

Step 1 – Roll:

1d20. A natural 20 always hits.

Step 2 – Identify:

It's a critical: natural 20, or a hit on an unconscious/paralyzed target within 5 ft.

Step 3 – Double dice:

Roll **all** damage dice twice (weapon + bonus dice).

Step 4 – Modifiers:

Add them **only once**.

Step 5 – Resistances:

Apply resistance or vulnerability **after** the total.

Example: Lyra (rapier 1d8 +3, Sneak Attack 2d6) crits: 2d8 + 4d6 + 3 damage.

Damage element	On a critical
Weapon dice (1d8, 2d6…)	Doubled
Sneak Attack dice	Doubled
Smite or spell dice	Doubled
Ability modifier	Added once
Flat bonuses (+1 magic weapon)	Added once
Saving throw spell dice	No critical

⚠ Common questions:

Does a 20 always hit?

Yes, even against a very high AC.

What is doubled?

Damage dice, not modifiers.

Do spells crit?

Yes, with an attack roll.

And saving throws?

No, no crit.

Is Sneak Attack doubled?

Yes, its dice are doubled.

Is there a fumble on a 1?

No, just a miss.

⚠ Debate points and table options: Table rule

Max damage

Is the first die maximized? **Option**: yes, plus one roll.

Crit on a save

Does a 20 double? **Option**: no.

Fumble

Does a 1 make it worse? **Option**: no, no table.

Expanded crit range

Some classes crit on 19. **Option**: follow the class text.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Bonus dice

Smites, Sneak Attack: dice doubled.

Modifiers

Added once.

Resistance

Applied after doubling.

These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.

Notices: This work includes material from the System Reference Document 5.2.1 (“SRD 5.2.1”) by Wizards of the Coast LLC, available at https://www.dndbeyond.com/srd. The SRD 5.2.1 is licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International License, available at https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/legalcode. Unofficial sheet, 5E compatible (2024 rules), neither approved nor sponsored by Wizards of the Coast. Rules come from SRD 5.2.1; where the SRD gives no answer, explanations rely on our own interpretation. The “Table rule” parts are the author’s own creations. Borders, banner, texture, titles, layout, table rules and examples: © Jaja, all rights reserved. Sources: SRD 5.2.1 (official English version); rule clarifications cross-checked with answers found on the web and reworded; numeric examples are invented; last revised: November 2026. Fonts: TeX Gyre Pagella (GUST), DejaVu Sans, Noto Color Emoji (OFL).